Interview Do's and Don'ts for Red Cross Workers

This document provides suggestions for conducting interviews with the media



Don't do an interview with someone who walks up to you and asks for one. Instead, make sure that you've first vetted the request with your local communications colleague prior to participation.

Don't fake an answer. Don't feel you have to answer every question posed by a reporter. If it is outside of your area of expertise, admit it.

Don't say "No Comment." It will take years to overcome the negative publicity when the public hears you say "No comment." There are times when you shouldn't answer a reporter's question: when it's proprietary information; or when there is pending legal action and your attorneys say you can't comment about specifics. However, explain that and then bridge to information that you would like the public to know in the subject area, even if you cannot comment on the specific question.

Don't go off the record. The information you give "off the record" may end up in the newspaper story or on the air. Although it may

not be attributed directly to you, it's not worth the risk of having potentially damaging information associated with you.

Don't answer multiple questions. Don't feel compelled to try to remember three or four questions that a reporter asks in a group. That's designed to intimidate you. Pick out the one you want to answer, or the last one asked, or group them into one subject area and select the sound bite you want the public to hear.

Don't fill the embarrassing silence. Let's assume you've just given your answer to a reporter, and you've Stopped!. Then, the interviewer looks up from the reporter's pad at you and doesn't say anything, or leaves a microphone in your face and is silent. It's a ploy to lure you into saying something that is not well thought out, maybe something you normally wouldn't say to the reporter. You fill the embarrassing silence and it could be disastrous. Don't!

Don't lose your cool. You will alienate the print reporter. In a broadcast interview, all that will end up on the air is you losing your temper, never the reporter's provocation.

Don't ask to review or edit the story. That request suggests that you might want to censor the story. A good reporter won't allow that. However, make sure the reporter knows how to contact you if more information is needed.



Do remember your relationship with the reporter. The reporter is not a judge and you are not a witness under subpoena. You do not

have to accommodate the reporter who tries to badger you or lead you down the primrose path. You are an expert with knowledge in specific areas. The reporter must write a story or get something "in the can" before the next newscast. The reporter is a vehicle through which you reach your public.

Do listen carefully to the entire question. Don't allow yourself to become so enamored with the style of the reporter that you forget to concentrate on the question and how you can effectively inform the reporter's public in the subject area.

Do look at the reporter's eyes. The reporter or the viewing public will distrust anyone who looks far away from the reporter's eyes, as though they must be hiding something. Naturally, you can't stare constantly at a reporter, so give occasional relief with a brief glance away, then back to the reporter's eyes.

Do establish your own intensity level. The great majority of interviewees are so preoccupied with the content of their message that they forget to show enthusiasm. You cannot afford to be blase about your ideas or your cause. Your enthusiasm conveys that you care. Therefore, establish your own intensity level that says "I really care about this." That's infectious. And, it prevents you from the natural tendency to copy the demeanor of the reporter who is interviewing you.

Do tell the truth. Don't open the "dirty linen closet" and tell the reporter all the negatives about you or your organization. But, by all means, tell the truth when asked. The reporter may know the truth, and if you're not forthcoming with it, you lose all credibility.

Do watch your jargon. As with any organization, the Red Cross has its own terms and acronyms. Terms such as ERVs or LDVs are not self-explanatory and the reporter's public may not understand your jargon. Match your language to the knowledge level of the reporter's public, and you cannot possibly be misunderstood.

Do lead the reporter. If there are important points you want to make, lead the reporter into inquiring about those points. For example, in your answer you might say "That's just one of the many ways were being flexible in our service delivery to meet the unique

needs of the victims of this disaster." The reporter is compelled to ask what those "many ways" are.

Do correct mistakes on the spot. Reporters know you're human and can make mistakes during an interview. If you fail to correct them, you lose credibility and so may the reporter. If you correct them immediately, you gain credibility.

Do take control if bullied. Most reporters are responsible journalist who are trying to elicit facts, feelings, opinions and judgements from you. Some reporters use intimidating questions or techniques designed to lure you into making provocative, indiscreet, controversial, titillating or revealing statements. If a reporter uses intimidating techniques - asks you multiple questions, interrupts you, raises voice volume, speeds up questions, invades your space, touches you, recognizing the technique and remaining calm and refusing to be intimidated can put you back in control of the interview.

Do remember why you are doing this interview. You are doing this interview to accomplish your agenda, namely getting the best possible information to the reporter's public about you, your organization or your cause.

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